21.4.2 Heirloom seed

An heirloom seed is the seed of plant that has been carefully cultivated and passed down through many generations. Heirlooms are usually planted in small, isolated communities and they generally offer something of value to the grower. Heirloom seeds are also called organic seeds. These seeds are generally produced from open-pollinated plants and they transfer their unique characteristics to the descendants. Heirloom seed are harvested, dried and stored so that one can replant them in the following season.

The goal of preserving heirloom seed is to prevent any type of change due to outside influence. Most vegetable and flower varieties must be kept protected or isolated from other similar varieties during flowering to avoid cross pollinating plants and mixing their genes. Some vegetable varieties are self-pollinated and are grown with virtually no danger of crossing. Synthetic fertilizers, herbicides or pesticides are not used for organic seeds but conventional fertilizer, herbicides and pesticides are used.

21.5 Bio-indicators

A bio-indicator or biological indicator is any species or group of species whose function or status reveals the qualitative status of the environment. Biological indicators are used to document and understand changes in earth's living systems especially changes caused by the activities of an expanding human population. Bio-indicators of soil health give us information about soil structure, development, nutrient storage and biological activities.

Biological indicator characterises the state of an ecosystem and brings its modifications. *Lichen* is a natural bio-indicator of climate change and air pollution effect. It is a combination of an alga and a fungus which live together in symbiotic association. *Lichen* is a sensitive environmental parameter like temperature, humidity, wind and air pollutants. It gives information about changes in climate, air quality and biological process.



Figure 21.20 Lichen

21.6 Agriculture Research Institutions

Agricultural research institutions formulate the agricultural practices based on recent research results and farmers' needs. Using suitable media and methods, they disseminate those information for the welfare of the people. Indian Agricultural Research Institute and Indian Council of Agricultural Research are some of the institutions which are involved in agricultural research.

21.6.1 Indian Agricultural Research Institute (IARI)

The Indian Agricultural Research Institute is a national institute for agricultural research, education and extension. IARI is commonly known as the Pusa Institute.



Figure 21.21 The Indian Agricultural Research Institute

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